

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

- A. The patient is at risk for double depression.
- B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.
- C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.
- D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

<think>

Finding reasoning paths :

- 1 . Persistent sadness -> Depression -> Risk of suicide
- 2 . Persistent sadness -> Depression -> Negative outlook on life
- 3 . Persistent sadness -> Depression -> Difficulty with decision-making and energy levels

Reasoning Process :

- 1 . **Persistent Sadness and Depression**: The patient reports feeling sad for as long as they can remember , which is a hallmark of persistent depressive disorder , commonly known as dysthymia . This condition often involves a low mood and a lack of interest in daily activities , leading to a pessimistic outlook on life .
- 2 . **Negative Outlook on Life**: The patient 's belief that " something terrible can happen to him " and the general pessimism about life are indicative of a negative outlook . This aligns with the symptoms of depression , particularly dysthymia , where individuals often feel helpless and cursed .
- 3 . **Difficulty with Decision-Making and Energy Levels**: The patient reports difficulty making decisions and experiencing low energy . These are common symptoms of depression , which can manifest in varying degrees of severity . In this case , the symptoms have worsened over the past 2 weeks , suggesting a possible progression to major depressive disorder .
- 4 . **Risk of Suicide**: The worsening suicidal ideations over the past month raise a significant concern . While the patient is able to maintain employment and sleep , these positive coping mechanisms may not fully mitigate the risk of suicide . The combination of persistent sadness , negative outlook , and suicidal ideations is concerning and may indicate a need for urgent psychiatric intervention .

Conclusion :

The patient 's condition appears to be indicative of persistent depressive disorder (dysthymia) , which involves a persistent low mood and pessimism about life . However , the recent worsening of suicidal ideations and energy levels suggest a possible progression to major depressive disorder . This condition comes with a risk of suicide , which is a serious and urgent concern . Immediate psychiatric assessment and support are critical for this patient .

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< answer >

The patient is at risk for double depression .

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